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O

oath

When people make a promise to each other, they can swear an **oath** to make the promise more serious. When someone swears an oath, they say: “I will absolutely keep my promise. If I do not, God may punish me.”

If someone did not keep his promise after swearing an oath, we say that he has broken his oath. It was an utterly disgraceful and dangerous thing to break an oath.

When God made a promise to people, he often made an oath as well. There is no one higher than God who can punish God if he breaks an oath, so God made these oaths in his own name, meaning that he would punish himself if he broke his promise.

oath

Audio Content

[mp3 file](#) (577773 KB)

offering

An **offering** is a gift or sacrifice offered in a ritual to God, usually in the temple or on a special altar. People can make offerings for many reasons, including to give thanks, to be purified, or to ask forgiveness for sin.

offering

Audio Content

[mp3 file](#) (202844 KB)

offering-grain

t260: grain offering

The Hebrew word that people usually translate as “grain offering” is a normal word for a gift that people would give human kings to honor them or for a gift that people would give to a powerful and important human. People might give a powerful and important person a gift to ask the powerful person for a favor or to appease the anger of that powerful person. When people gave this kind of gift to another human, they might give money, animals, nuts, spices, or anything else that people thought was valuable.

When Yahweh gave Moses instructions for the people of Israel, Yahweh chose to use this word to describe a specific kind of offering that Yahweh’s people would give Yahweh. When Yahweh and the people of Israel

made a binding agreement, or a covenant, with each other, the people of Israel agreed that Yahweh would be the king of their nation. So every morning and every evening, Yahweh’s priests would give Yahweh an offering of grain, oil, and salt to honor Yahweh as the king of their nation. Every week on the Sabbath day of rest, and every month during the new moon festival, Yahweh’s priests would give Yahweh an additional offering of grain, oil, and salt to honor Yahweh as the king of their nation. Yahweh’s priests also gave Yahweh additional gifts of grain, oil, and salt during yearly festivals. During one of these festivals, which people called the Feast of Firstfruits, the people of Israel would give Yahweh some of their crops as this kind of offering to thank Yahweh for giving them a harvest.

People could also give Yahweh this kind of offering if they wanted to ask Yahweh for a favor or to thank him for having done them a favor in the past. Sometimes, people also brought this kind of offering as part of a cleansing ritual.

Yahweh said that this kind of offering was most holy. That meant that priests had to treat this offering with special respect because this offering made whoever and whatever touched it holy to Yahweh. So, the priests would burn up part of the offering on the bronze altar and eat the rest. Only Aaron and his male descendants could eat the leftover portion of this offering.

offering-grain

Audio Content

[mp3 file](#) (1756310 KB)

oil lamp

The people of Israel used **oil lamps** to help them see in the dark. People made lamps out of clay that was burned in an oven to make it hard. People could also cut lamps out of stone. Many oil lamps simply looked a bit as if someone pinched the edge of a bowl together, but other oil lamps were more elaborate. People put oil in the bowl. Usually this was olive oil, which came from the fruit from an olive tree. Then people put a strip of cloth in the bowl: One end rested inside the oil, and the other end rested on the rim of the lamp. The strip of cloth is called a wick. The wick would soak up the oil. People would then light the wick. The lamp would keep burning as long as there was oil, or until the wick would be burned up completely.

Inside a house, people would put oil lamps on stands so that they would be higher up and give more light.

You may want to look at some pictures of oil lamps.

oil lamp

Audio Content

[mp3 file](#) (728421 KB)